STAYMAN CONVENTION

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

STAYMAN CONVENTION SUMMARY

When one partner opens 1NT it is difficult to uncover a 4-4 Major fit using only natural bidding. The Stayman Convention solves the problem and improves bidding accuracy as well. As an additional benefit, when you use Stayman the 1NT Opener usually becomes the Declarer on the hand, thereby keeping the stronger hand concealed.

The Stayman Convention is worthwhile even if it is the only convention you use. However, there are added benefits to using Stayman in conjunction with Jacoby Transfers. The two work smoothly together with Stayman taking care of those hands where Responder has a 4-card Major(s) and Jacoby Transfers taking care of those hands where Responder has a 5- or 6-card Major.

The actual working of Stayman is simple:
Following a 1NT opening, Responder will only use Stayman when he holds at least one 4-card Major suit.
He does so by bidding 2♣ which requires Opener to reply as follows:

- With no 4-card Major suit he bids 2♦.
- With a 4-card ♥ suit, (and possibly 4 ♠s as well), he bids 2♥.
- With a 4-card ♠ suit, (but not 4 ♥s), he bids 2♠.

It really is as simple as that. Well, almost.

Stayman takes much of the guesswork (sometimes called judgement) out of the bidding and steers you directly to these two goals:

1. With a partnership 26 points you will reach game, with 33 you will reach slam.
2. With a partnership 8+ cards in a Major suit you will play in that suit, otherwise you will play notrump.

For the first point consider this table which is based on the 1NT opener holding 15-17 points.

Resp Points	Opener Points			Bidding Target
	15	16	17	
8	23	24	25	Partscore
9	24	25	26	
10	25	26	27	
11	26	27	28	
12	27	28	29	Game
13	28	29	30	
14	29	30	31	
15	30	31	32	
16	31	32	33	
17	32	33	34	Slam
18	33	34	35	

Responder's actions are as follows:

- 8 points or fewer - usually pass, but may use Stayman and then pass
- 9 points - invite partner to game
- 10 points - either invite or force to game, using your judgement
- 11-15 points - force to game
- 16 points - invite to slam
- 17 points - either invite or force to slam, using your judgement
- 18 points or more - force to slam

Opener's actions are as follows:

- 15 points - decline invitations
- 16 points - either decline or accept, using your judgement
- 17 points - accept invitations

As to the second point above (the 8-card trump fit) Responder is usually in charge.

- If Opener shows a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks that suit.
- If Opener does not show a 4-card Major which matches one held by Responder, then Responder picks notrump.

Opener usually has no say in the suit selection, with this important exception:
If Opener holds 4 cards in **EACH** Major suit he responds 2♥.
Should Responder then bid notrump, indicating a dislike for ♥s, Opener should bid ♠s because she knows there is a 4-4 ♠ fit,

Some comments are in order about the point count methods used on these pages.
Initial point count for both hands is based on 4-3-2-1 plus one point for a fifth card in a suit.
Revalued points (only after a trump fit is discovered) are +1 for a doubleton, +2 for a singleton and +3 for a void. Both hands should count these revalued short-suit points; Opener of course would not have a singleton or void.

One more point. Stayman should definitely be used after 2NT openings as well.

25 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 1NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥3

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠8

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥3

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣4

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦J

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣7

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K 10 8 2
♥ 7 4
♦ A K 6 3
♣ A J 7

♠ Q J 7 5
♥ Q 6
♦ Q J 4
♣ 10 4 3 2



♠ 9 6 3
♥ A 10 5 3 2
♦ 9 5
♣ K Q 9

♠ A 4
♥ K J 9 8
♦ 10 8 7 2
♣ 8 6 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT		
All Pass			

1NT by North
Lead: ♥3

North opens 1NT.

If partner has a 4-card ♥ suit to match yours you could revalue your hand and add a point for your doubleton ♠. That would give you the 9 points you need for an invitational response.

It is far too risky to play for that possibility. So you just pass.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 2 ♥ Q 5 4 ♦ 6 5 3 ♣ A 9 7 4 3	
♠ A 4 ♥ A J 9 8 ♦ 10 8 7 2 ♣ 8 6 5		♠ K Q J 5 ♥ 10 6 3 ♦ A Q 9 ♣ K Q 10
	♠ 9 8 7 6 3 ♥ K 7 2 ♦ K J 4 ♣ J 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠8

East opens 1NT.

You have 9 points and a 4-card Major. Just enough for an invitational Stayman sequence. You bid 2♣ and partner answers 2♠.

Partner has the wrong Major. Now that you know there is no 8-card Major fit you must go to notrump. And since you don't have the strength to insist on game you say 2NT which is an invitation for partner to bid 3NT if he has a maximum.

He has a maximum and he bids 3NT.

Board 3
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K Q 10 6 ♥ 9 6 4 ♦ K J 10 8 ♣ 7 3	
♠ 7 5 ♥ J 8 3 2 ♦ 7 4 2 ♣ A 10 6 5	N W E S	♠ J 4 2 ♥ Q 10 7 ♦ Q 6 3 ♣ K Q 8 2
	♠ A 9 8 3 ♥ A K 5 ♦ A 9 5 ♣ J 9 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♥3

South opens 1NT.

Of course you bid 2♣. Partner now bids 2♠. What is your next bid?

Partner hit your suit. When you add a point for your doubleton ♣ you are up to 10 points. This is the situation where you have to use your judgement, either to invite or to bid the game yourself.

There is really no right or wrong here, between 3♠ and 4♠. Those extra 10's and 9's swing you to 4♠. As you see it will be a close call, but even if you misguess the ♦ finesse you will still establish a ♦ winner for a discard.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 8 ♥ 8 7 6 ♦ J 9 4 ♣ A 9 5 4 3	
♠ 9 6 5 ♥ A 9 ♦ A Q 10 5 ♣ K Q 8 6		♠ A J 10 4 ♥ K Q J 5 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ J 7
	♠ K 7 3 2 ♥ 10 4 3 2 ♦ K 7 2 ♣ 10 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♦	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♣4

West opens 1NT.

Both Majors! Lucky you. So you bid a Stayman 2♣. Unfortunately partner comes back with 2♦. What is your next bid?

Partner doesn't have a 4-card Major so your side doesn't have an 8-card Major fit. Therefore you will play in notrump. And with your 12 points you **MUST** play in game. So you bid 3NT.

Board 5
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 10 9 8 2 ♥ K Q 6 ♦ A 9 4 ♣ A K 5	
♠ 6 5 ♥ 10 8 4 3 ♦ K Q 8 3 ♣ 10 6 2		♠ A 7 4 ♥ 9 7 2 ♦ J 10 6 5 ♣ Q J 7
	♠ K Q J 3 ♥ A J 5 ♦ 7 2 ♣ 9 8 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦J

North opens 1NT.

With 11 points and a 4-card Major suit you bid 2♣. Partner answers 2♠. What is your next bid?

Stayman bidding can be very straightforward. Partner has 4 ♠s, you have 4 ♠s. That makes 8. Partner has 15-17 points, you have 11-12 points. That makes 26-29.

You bid 4♠.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ J 8 6 3 ♥ 4 3 2 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ J 9 8	
♠ A 10 9 4 ♥ K J 10 7 ♦ A J ♣ K Q 3	N W E S	♠ K Q 5 ♥ Q 9 5 ♦ K Q 9 4 ♣ A 6 2
	♠ 7 2 ♥ A 8 6 ♦ 10 7 5 2 ♣ 10 7 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
6NT			
All Pass			

6NT by East
Lead: ♣7

East opens 1NT.

You have a very big hand. Enormous. But you also have two 4-card Majors, so the first step is Stayman. You bid 2♣ and partner replies 2♦.

You have 18 points and partner has 15, 16 or 17. Your total is between 33 and 35. You have enough POINTS for a small slam, not enough for a grand. You have no Major suit fit, and are happy to play notrump.

There is a lot to be said for bidding 6NT immediately. You could ask for Aces if you like but whether partner shows one or two isn't going to change your decision. Be bold.